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Understanding Online Freelancers' Labour Agency at the Intersection of Platforms, Wider Labour Markets, and Households: Evidence From the Philippines

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ABSTRACT

Research on the labour agency of remote-based online freelancers has often struggled to account for the interplay between platform dynamics, broader labour market conditions, and gendered household responsibilities. This article addresses this gap by proposing an integrated analytical framework that synthesises these dimensions to examine how freelancers exercise their labour agency in choosing between different online jobs—decisions which are vital to their platform success. Drawing on in-depth interviews with 25 Filipino freelancers, the findings show that freelancers exercise their agency by employing two overarching strategies: optimising their financial and temporal resources. These strategies are shaped by platform logics, as well as by constraints and opportunities linked to freelancers' wider labour market position and private-sphere responsibilities. The discussion demonstrates the framework's analytical value by illustrating how these strategies produce uneven implications for freelancers' longer-term platform trajectories, adding nuance to debates about the uneven gains of remote platform work.

1 | Introduction

On online freelance platforms such as Upwork and Freelancer.com, workers offer digitally transmittable services to clients worldwide, ranging from administrative support and legal services to software development (Beerepoot and Lambregts 2015). Unlike gig workers on crowdwork platforms (e.g., Amazon Mechanical Turk) and location-based platforms (e.g., Uber and Deliveroo), online freelancers can navigate these platforms relatively freely (Kalleberg and Dunn 2016). As research on online freelance labour has matured (Author's own 2024), a growing body of work has examined how freelancers exercise their labour agency in this context. Much of this literature has focused on platform-specific dynamics, such as reputation systems and algorithmic management (Bucher et al. 2021; Rahman 2021), as well as other technological resources wielded by platforms to enable and manage work

(Nemkova et al. 2019; Shevchuk et al. 2021; Anwar and Graham 2020; Sutherland et al. 2020; Jarrahi et al. 2020). Other studies have drawn attention to freelancers' embeddedness in labour-market segments beyond online freelance platforms, including local 'analogue' markets (Rahman 2021; Anwar and Graham 2020), or have examined how gendered social-reproductive responsibilities and household livelihood strategies shape platform behaviour (Foong et al. 2018; Dunn et al. 2021; Anwar 2022; James 2022, 2024). While these perspectives have advanced our understanding, they have often remained analytically separate. As a result, there remains a lack of understanding of how platform dynamics, broader labour-market conditions, and gendered household responsibilities interact in shaping freelancers' labour agency.

To address this gap, this article proposes an integrated analytical framework that synthesises these three interrelated

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dimensions. The framework is examined through an empirical focus on how freelancers choose between digital jobs on online freelance platforms. Given the small-scale and short-term nature of such jobs, freelancers must make job-selection decisions frequently (Graham et al. 2017), and these decisions carry considerable weight, as on-platform work histories are key determinants of future platform success (Fu et al. 2021; Leung 2014). Yet, there remains limited understanding of how freelancers exercise their agency when navigating these choices. Here, labour agency refers to the intentional, purposive, and meaningful pursuit of self-interest with limited resources (Coe and Jordhus-Lier 2011; Castree et al. 2004), exercised within—and shaped by—multiple, intersecting contexts.

Drawing on in-depth interviews with 25 freelancers registered on Upwork—one of the largest online freelance platforms worldwide (Kässi and Lehdonvirta 2018)—and living in the Philippines, a country often associated with the cheapest and most exploited online freelancers (Beerepoot and Lambregts 2015), the findings reveal that freelancers exercise their labour agency by employing two overarching strategies: optimising financial resources and managing temporal resources. These strategies are shaped by Upwork's platform logics, as well as by constraints and opportunities arising from freelancers' wider labour market position and private-sphere responsibilities. The discussion subsequently shows the analytical value of the proposed framework by shedding light on the uneven implications of these short-term strategies for freelancers' longer-term trajectories on the platform (Soriano and Cabañes 2019; Beerepoot and Lambregts 2015; Graham et al. 2017; Kinder et al. 2019; Anwar and Graham 2020).

2 | Conceptualising the Labour Agency of Online Freelancers

2.1 | Labour Agency Shaped by the Platform Environment

On online freelance platforms, freelancers are presented with a vast array of job opportunities and must carefully determine which ones to pursue (Stephany et al. 2021; Kässi and Lehdonvirta 2018; Kuek et al. 2015). This selective approach is further reinforced by measures implemented by platforms to lower the number of bids per job. These were introduced partly in response to a substantial oversupply of labour and a bid volume that far exceeds the number of available jobs (Beerepoot and Lambregts 2015; Gefen et al. 2016), which have made it increasingly difficult and time-consuming for clients to identify suitable freelancers. Platforms such as Upwork and Freelancer now require freelancers to use a certain number of tokens, referred to respectively as 'connects' and 'bids', when bidding for jobs. Each platform provides a small number of tokens free of charge, and freelancers must pay for additional tokens. By doing so, the platforms incentivise them to carefully review job posts to ensure they match their skills and availability (Upwork n.d.-a; Freelancer n.d.).

While existing research has touched on how freelancers select the jobs they pursue, to my knowledge, no study has examined this decision-making process in-depth. Nonetheless, prior work suggests that freelancers' choices are shaped by the platform environment. On one hand, this environment is structured by

what Jarrahi et al. (2020) term 'platformic management'—the broad set of technological resources and rules wielded by online freelance platforms to enable and manage work (p. 6). A prominent example is freelancers' platform reputation, typically based on client feedback and performance ratings, which platforms actively collect and prominently display. On the other hand, the platform environment is structured by informal platform norms, rules, and standards, such as the considerable value that clients give to freelancers' platform reputation (Author's own 2023). Consequently, research has identified the imperative to build and maintain a strong reputation as a notable driver of freelancers' job selection strategies. Particularly, new freelancers select easy, short-term jobs to quickly generate client feedback (Anwar and Graham 2020; Beerepoot and Lambregts 2015; Lehdonvirta et al. 2019; Idowu and Elbanna 2020; Kinder et al. 2019) and freelancers, whether new or experienced, are wary of bidding for challenging jobs as they fear bad reviews (Nemkova et al. 2019). Additionally, they carefully scrutinise clients before bidding for jobs to avoid disagreements that might hamper their platform reputation (Anwar and Graham 2020; Bucher et al. 2021; Jarrahi et al. 2020; Kinder et al. 2019; Wood and Lehdonvirta 2023).

As illustrated, the platform environment shapes freelancers' bidding decisions and strategies, yet their behaviour cannot be adequately understood through this lens alone. Freelancers' objectives, dependencies, interests, and actions are embedded in a multiplicity of contexts—historical, temporal, institutional, spatial, and social—each offering opportunities and constraints that are vital to understanding their economic behaviour (Van Doorn and Shapiro 2023; Bögenhold 2019; Welter 2011). As articulated within the structure-agency debate (e.g., see Giddens [1979] and Jessop [2001]), their actions are subject to multiple 'structures', that is, conditions that both enable and constrain human action, which influence if, how, and why freelancers seek to assert their labour agency (Coe and Jordhus-Lier 2011; Van Doorn and Shapiro 2023). This article argues that situating freelancers within a wider set of structures enables a more complex and nuanced understanding of heterogeneity in how they exercise their agency (Bögenhold 2019), thereby addressing critiques of limited accounts of individual differences (James 2022; Elbanna and Idowu 2022; Soriano and Cabañes 2019; Shevchuk et al. 2024).

2.2 | Broadening the Analytical Scope

The analytical scope is expanded by examining online freelancers' experiences with and perceptions of the labour market beyond a single online freelance platform. Research shows that their decision to venture into online freelancing is often driven by challenges in more traditional labour market segments (Oprins 2025), including unemployment (Idowu and Elbanna 2020; Anwar and Graham 2021; Dunn et al. 2021), underemployment (Bellesia et al. 2019; Taylor and Joshi 2019; Malik et al. 2021), and a lack of income (stability) (Soriano and Cabañes 2019, 2020; D'Cruz and Noronha 2016; Lehdonvirta et al. 2019; Anwar and Graham 2020). Once active on online freelance platforms, their agency continues to be shaped by their position in other labour market segments. For example, freelancers who depend heavily on a single platform are more likely to invest in rebuilding their platform reputation following

setbacks (Rahman 2021). Similarly, migrant workers unable to take up local employment have relatively limited on-platform agency, whereas freelancers who are already employed experience greater autonomy, for example, in choosing particular jobs (Anwar and Graham 2020; Dunn et al. 2021).

Building on these insights, this article conceptualises freelancers' bidding decisions and strategies as shaped by their standing in other labour market segments. Specifically, it considers their standing in the analogue, local labour market as well as the overseas labour market—a particularly salient segment in the Philippine context, where a significant portion of the workforce is employed abroad (PSA 2023). Additionally, it explores freelancers' alternative access to online freelance jobs, noting that many are registered on multiple online freelance platforms (Jarrahi et al. 2020) and also draw on their social network (Anwar and Graham 2020; Malik et al. 2021).

Across these various forms of work, freelancers possess certain legal rights and obligations and may or may not be entitled to social benefits. Academic literature has long recognised the role of such 'rules of the game' (Baumol 1996)—that is, the national regulatory environment—in shaping entrepreneurial activity (Welter 2011; Bögenhold 2019a; 2019). However, research on how national regulatory frameworks, particularly those in the Global South, influence online freelancers' agency remains limited. A study from the United States suggests that freelancers ineligible for social security experience greater precarity, which in turn constrains their on-platform autonomy (Dunn et al. 2021). This article examines these dynamics in the context of the Global South, where social benefits are typically less comprehensive, yet online freelance work enjoys significant popularity (Stephany et al. 2021).

The analytical scope is further broadened by incorporating the private realm. As highlighted by feminist-oriented scholars who challenge the notion that structure is solely defined by the capitalist system (Coe and Jordhus-Lier 2011), freelancers' bidding decisions and strategies cannot be separated from their private lives. These scholars advocate for a more expansive understanding of labour agency, one that accounts for how workers navigate gender ideologies, dynamics of social reproduction and household livelihood strategies (Coe and Jordhus-Lier 2011; Massey 1995; Katz 2001; Lier 2007; Mezzadri et al. 2022). This resonates with Handy's (1989) notion of *portfolio marriages*, which describes how households balance work portfolios by mixing risk and security and combining short-term income with long-term gains. Similarly, Bögenhold (2019) argues that shifting the analytical lens from the individual to the household level reveals how inner family dynamics shape employment strategies.

Inspired by these studies, this article adopts an analytical approach that foregrounds the role of gender norms, social reproduction, and household livelihood strategies in shaping freelancers' bidding decisions and strategies. In doing so, it contributes to a small but growing body of research on the labour agency of online freelancers that acknowledges its gendered nature (e.g., Foong et al. 2018; Dunn et al. 2021; Anwar 2022; James 2022, 2024). These studies generally argue that women's agency is relatively constrained by the unequal burden of social reproduction, resulting in online freelance labour reinforcing the gender inequalities existent in traditional

labour markets. However, with the exception of Anwar (2022), these studies are situated in the Global North. This geographic concentration limits our understanding of how agency unfolds in different socio-economic contexts, where gendered norms of capitalist production and social reproduction may differ substantially. By focusing on the Philippines, this article helps redress this imbalance and shows that insights derived from Global North contexts are not always directly transferable to Global South settings.

3 | Data and Methodology

Figure 1 presents the analytical framework proposed in the article. Its analytical value is examined by focussing on the following research question: how do freelancers exercise their agency in choosing online jobs? Two sub-questions were formulated:

- What strategies do freelancers use in choosing online jobs?
- How are these strategies shaped by considerations about the platform environment, the wider labour market, and freelancers' private life?

To answer these questions, this article draws on qualitative data that constitutes the first round of data collection of a larger longitudinal research project on the labour market agency of online freelancers. From June to August 2023, I conducted in-depth interviews with Filipino freelancers who were recruited through two Facebook groups dedicated to communally supporting Upwork freelancers from the Philippines. In these groups, I posted a call for participants, inviting any freelancer residing in the Philippines who had created an Upwork profile within the past 6 months, to respond.

I chose to recruit freelancers who were new to Upwork because, unlike experienced freelancers with an established platform reputation to whom work flows more easily, they have to actively search for and choose online jobs to bid for (Wood et al. 2019a; Anwar and Graham 2020; Jarrahi et al. 2020). In the call for participants, I also noted that participants would be offered a monetary reward of 15 euros (approximately 850 Philippine pesos), a common approach used by researchers to recruit online freelancers (e.g., see Wood et al. (2019b), Wood and Lehdonvirta (2023), and James (2024)). Approximately 500 people responded, after which purposive sampling was used, aiming for diversity in terms of place of residence (level of urbanisation), sex, and the type of services offered (see Table 1). Ultimately, 25 participants were selected who broadly reflect the characteristics of Filipino online freelancers. Most reside in highly urbanised cities, are women, and provide lower-skilled services such as administrative support and customer service (Beerepoot and Oprins 2022; Beerepoot and Lambregts 2015). Participants ranged in age from 22 to 40, with one participant aged 52. To protect anonymity, pseudonyms were assigned. Importantly, all but one participant had actively applied for jobs on Upwork at the time of the interview; the remaining participant was waiting for clients to reach out. His inclusion nevertheless proved valuable, as his approach reflected considerations arising from the broader labour market and private realm.

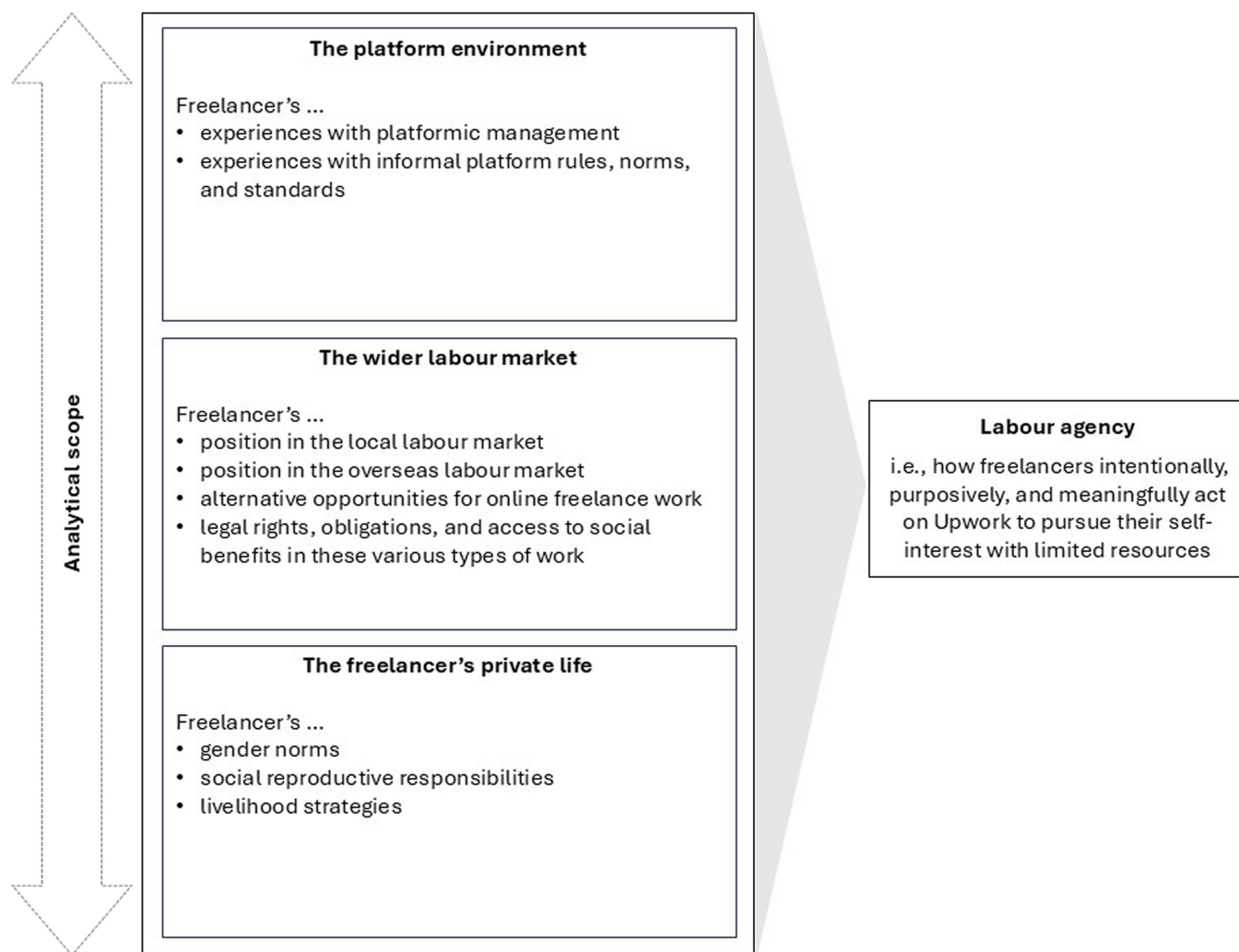


FIGURE 1 | Analytical framework: labour agency as shaped by three structures.

TABLE 1 | Characteristics of interview participants.

Participant characteristics	Highly urbanised city ^a	Component city
<i>N</i>	16	9
Female/male	10/6	4/5
<i>Type of service offered</i>		
Admin support	87.5%	67%
Customer service	37.5%	11%
Sales & marketing	25%	44%
Writing	12.5%	11%
Translation	12.5%	0%
Design & creative	0%	22%

^aHighly urbanised cities have a minimum population of 200,000 and an annual income of at least 50 million Philippine pesos, based on 1991 constant prices. Component cities do not meet these requirements (NSCB n.d.; PSA 2025a; PSA 2025b).

Interviews were conducted either in person or online, following a semi-structured protocol informed by the analytical framework. The interview guide was organised around the framework's three analytical dimensions, most prominently discussed in the

literature, with tailored questions developed for each. To explore participants' experiences with the Upwork platform environment, a walkthrough analysis was conducted in advance to inform questions about specific platform features (Light et al. 2018), and each participant's individual platform profile was examined prior to the interview. To capture participants' position in the wider labour market, questions addressed their offline employment histories as well as their experienced and perceived job opportunities and challenges in the Philippines and abroad. With regard to participants' private lives, questions about daily routines were used to inform a more detailed inquiry into social reproductive and financial responsibilities and household livelihood strategies. All interviews were conducted after obtaining informed consent, lasted between 45 and 90 min, were audio-recorded, and subsequently transcribed verbatim.

During the interviews, it appeared that some participants had initially created their Upwork profile over 6 months prior. However, at that time, they never managed to land a job and they had only recently decided to revive their online freelance career. Therefore, similar to freelancers who had only recently signed up on Upwork, they needed to actively search for and choose jobs to pursue (Wood et al. 2019a; Anwar and Graham 2020; Jarrahi et al. 2020).

The analysis was inspired by Template Analysis, a form of thematic analysis that integrates a hierarchical, theory-driven process with a flexible, data-driven approach (Brooks et al. 2015). An initial coding template was informed by the three analytical dimensions outlined in Figure 1, which served as guiding concepts rather than fixed categories. Within this structure, interview transcripts were coded inductively to capture participants' own accounts of how they selected and pursued jobs on the platform. This process resulted in 56 codes, including, for example, 'apply for jobs that fully match skills and experience', and 'apply for stable jobs'. While most codes could be situated primarily within one analytical dimension, several cut across dimensions. For instance, 'apply for time-flexible jobs' reflected both participants' position in the wider labour market and their social reproductive responsibilities in the private sphere. In a subsequent analytic step, codes were compared across participants to identify commonalities and differences and to examine how these related to the interplay between the platform environment, participants' position in the wider labour market, and their private lives.

4 | Contextual Background

4.1 | Labour and Gender in the Philippines

The Philippines is classified as a lower-middle-income country, with a gross national income per capita of \$3950 in 2023 (World Bank 2024). Over the past decades, driven by the remarkable growth of the information technology business process outsourcing (IT-BPO) sector, the Philippine economy has transitioned from an agriculture-based to a service-oriented economy (Beerepoot and Oprins 2022; World Bank 2023). The country's well-educated, English-proficient workforce, has positioned the Philippines as the second-largest recipient of internationally relocated service activities (Kleibert 2015; Lambregts et al. 2016; IBPAP 2022). Today, the IT-BPO sector employs over 1.5 million Filipinos, offering not only substantial employment but also relative job stability and affordable access to healthcare insurance, advantages often lacking in other sectors of the economy (IBPAP 2022; Soriano and Cabañes 2019). Participants residing in highly urbanised areas reported that such opportunities were generally within reach and therefore did not express concerns about securing traditional offline employment.

Despite these advantages, there are also some challenges associated with employment in the IT-BPO sector. Workers often face long and exhausting commutes, along with limited time-space flexibility and few opportunities for personal and career growth. As a result, despite the sector's reputation for being 'hip' and prestigious, its popularity has begun to decline—an observation confirmed by the participants in this study (Soriano and Cabañes 2019). In addition, employment in the IT-BPO sector is primarily accessible to college graduates in highly urbanised areas (Soriano and Cabañes 2019), while alternative job opportunities for less-educated workers and those in rural regions remain limited (World Bank 2023). Participants' accounts echoed these structural divides. The Philippines has also been struggling with a substantial number of working poor. Despite having an income, they are unable to lift themselves and their families out of poverty (World Bank 2023) and this problem has likely worsened over the past few years, wherein

annual inflation was high (around 6% in 2022 and 2023), but wages stagnated (PSA 2024a). These concerns were also present among interview participants, many of whom emphasised that local wages were insufficient to meet rising household expenses.

Resulting from these challenges and following a decade-long government policy which promotes labour emigration, millions of Filipinos choose to work abroad (Opiniano and Ang 2024). Labour migration is so ingrained in Philippine society that 7% of households are home to overseas Filipino workers (OFW) and 20% of Filipinos are hoping to live abroad (Valmonte 2023). However, only two participants considered overseas work a viable option in the near future. Most were reluctant to leave their families or lacked the required financial resources.

Another challenge is the relatively low female labour force participation rate (World Bank 2021). Just over half of Filipino women is formally¹ part of the labour force versus nearly 75% of men (PSA 2024b). The gap is largest among married men and women aged between 20 and 39, with nearly 90% of women attributing their absence to social reproductive responsibilities (World Bank 2021). As for women who are formally employed, particularly those at peak reproductive ages between 25 and 39 years old, they often work fewer hours than men and are more likely to be self-employed. This suggests that women more frequently choose employment that provides the flexibility needed to balance waged- with social reproductive labour (World Bank 2021). These patterns were reflected in this study's interviews, where many women emphasised the need to combine waged labour with caregiving tasks.

In an effort to mitigate these labour market challenges, the Philippine government has initiated road shows and technical training programmes aimed at promoting and supporting online freelance work as an alternative livelihood for socio-economically disadvantaged groups, including rural workers, non-college graduates, and women (Beerepoot and Oprins 2022; DOST 2015; Peña and Yao 2022; PIA 2025). Although the impact of these initiatives remains unclear and comprehensive statistics on Filipino participation in online freelancing are lacking, existing evidence shows that Filipinos are disproportionately active on online freelance platforms (Stephany et al. 2021; Upwork 2020). Their engagement is driven by opportunities for upward career mobility, autonomy and flexibility, higher wages, and more quality time with their families (Beerepoot and Oprins 2022; Soriano and Cabañes 2019).

4.2 | Upwork

Among Filipino freelancers, Upwork is well known, with participation concentrated in lower-skill market segments such as administrative support (Beerepoot and Lambregts 2015). The platform offers keyword search and filtering tools that help freelancers refine job listings, for instance, by job category (e.g., accounting and consulting, admin support, customer service), experience level (entry, intermediate, or expert), hourly and fixed rate, number of submitted proposals, and clients' number of previous on-platform hires. Freelancers can subsequently sort results by 'newest' and 'relevance' and access detailed information by clicking on specific listings. To bid for a job, they must pay a certain number of connects (Basuthakur 2024;

Upwork n.d.-a). At the time of data collection, this ranged from two to sixteen, with the actual amount being determined by Upwork based on the 'potential value' of a job (Ross n.d.). Depending on the account type, Freelancer Basic (free) or Freelancer Plus (\$20 USD a month), freelancers received respectively 10 or 100 connects monthly and they could buy additional connects for \$0.15 USD per connect (Upwork n.d.-a).

5 | Findings

The findings show that freelancers exercise their agency by employing two overarching strategies when selecting and pursuing jobs on Upwork: optimising their financial resources and managing their temporal resources. While these resources are closely intertwined in practice, Sections 5.1 and 5.2 examine them separately to demonstrate how freelancers' job selection practices are shaped by the interplay between the platform environment, their position within the wider labour market, and the circumstances of their private lives. Together, these dimensions illustrate how freelancers' labour agency is developed and conditioned at the intersection of multiple structures.

5.1 | Optimising Financial Resources

Participants explained how Upwork's platform environment requires new freelancers to allocate their already limited financial resources in specific ways. Pursuing jobs typically involves upfront expenditures, including the purchase of connects, the payment of platform fees, and the acceptance of low-wage entry-level jobs. This section examines each of these requirements in turn, illustrating how some participants aligned their practices with these platform logics, while others—due to their position in the wider labour market and the circumstances of their private lives—were unable or unwilling to do so.

First, Upwork requires freelancers to pay connects for every bid. New-to-the-platform freelancers depend heavily on these connects to initiate contact with clients, whereas more established freelancers with a solid platform reputation often receive direct invitations instead (Wood et al. 2019a; Anwar and Graham 2020; Jarrahi et al. 2020). Participants consistently described the connect system as a financial burden, noting that only a small number of connects are provided for free and that purchasing additional ones is often unaffordable. As Ethan put it, 'it's very costly to connect to clients' (male, component city). This requirement reflects a central aspect of the platform environment, in which access to jobs is mediated by platform-specific rules and financial thresholds. Yet, most participants struggled to follow this logic because the financial pressures within their private lives left them with little room to invest upfront. Jacob, for example, turned to Upwork to supplement his family's income during a period of hardship, but the very situation also meant that he could not afford to purchase additional connects, explaining that he was 'at Upwork to earn and not really to spend' (male, highly urbanised city).

Rather than purchasing additional connects, participants sought to maximise the value of their limited free connects by navigating the Upwork platform environment in ways that

reduced the financial risk of bidding. They applied only when they believed their skills and experience aligned exactly with a job's requirements, carefully assessing each posting to avoid 'wasting'—as Myra (female, highly urbanised) put it—scarce connects on proposals they viewed as unlikely to succeed. As she explained:

I need to read all that was written on the job requirements, so that I would gonna think and decide if.. can I do this? And then another question is: will he hire me? [..] Like, did I meet those requirements that he or she was posting on it? And then that's the reason that I will gonna send proposals to them.

Such caution suggests that freelancers tend to pursue only those jobs they already feel confident in performing, which may limit opportunities for on-the-job learning. This pattern echoes concerns raised by Graham et al. (2017) that platform labour can result in skill stagnation or even downskilling. In contrast, for several participants, online freelance platforms served as a driver of professional upskilling and reskilling (see also Elbanna and Idowu 2021; Seppänen et al. 2021; Sutherland et al. 2020). They stressed not only the importance of possessing relevant skills and experience, but also the need to prove this to clients. Accordingly, they had invested or were considering investing in online courses to obtain certificates.

Additionally, participants took considerable effort to scrutinise clients and jobs before bidding, again to avoid 'wasting' their connects (see also Anwar and Graham 2020; Bucher et al. 2021; Jarrahi et al. 2020; Kinder et al. 2019; Wood and Lehdonvirta 2023). While they appreciated Upwork's trust-enhancing features, including clients' reputation, dispute resolution, and payment protection, many remained wary of scams and illegitimate postings. These concerns were driven by accounts from fellow freelancers and, in some cases, personal experiences. As such, they mostly applied for jobs from clients who's payment method had been verified by Upwork. As Princess explained:

I always check if the payment is verified because I don't want to waste my connects and time applying for jobs that is not real or scam.

(female, component city)

Participants also favoured clients with a transaction history and positive feedback from previous hires, indicating that it is not only clients who rely on feedback to gauge the reliability of potential business partners (Beerepoot et al. 2023). Many went even further by searching the internet to verify clients' legitimacy. Additionally, five participants reported checking clients' locations, expressing caution toward clients from certain regions. This suggests that also biased perceptions and discriminatory practices go both ways (Chan and Wang 2018; Ghani et al. 2014).

Second, Upwork charges service fees, requiring freelancers to surrender a percentage of their on-platform earnings in exchange for the services the platform provides (Upwork n.d.-b). While some participants accepted these obligatory fees—which,

if not adhered to, could lead to temporary suspension—others found it difficult to comply. This difficulty emerged from the interaction between the platform environment, which imposes non-negotiable deductions on earnings, and freelancers' financial responsibilities within their private lives, which left little room to absorb these costs. This applied not only to those who identified as primary earners, but also to participants whose household budgets were already stretched and needed all available income to get by every month. As a result, these participants accepted offers from clients who wished to work off-platform, enabling the latter to pay lower rates because no percentage was deducted by Upwork. Kyle, for instance, described how his family's financial needs compelled him to work off-platform when clients proposed it. As he explained:

My rate is \$4. So I would work 8 h a day, that's 160 per week. And then they [referring to Upwork] get 10%. That's \$16, that's around 700 pesos. And then [...] Upwork also has a withdrawal charge of \$2. That's basically \$18, almost 1000 [pesos] in fees. I think that's why I risk it sometimes. Because Upwork fee is too heavy for my budget.

(male, component city)

A third financial requirement arising from Upwork's platform environment relates to freelancers' platform reputation and clients' strong emphasis on on-platform work experience and demonstrable skills, while largely disregarding freelancers' off-platform educational and professional achievements. As Ines, who had over fifteen years of work experience and had previously served as a school head, explained:

if you are new in Upwork but with a lot of experience, you might be thinking that it's going to be easy for you to land a job there, since you have a lot of skill set, you have a lot of experiences. But then um.. it's not the case. Oftentimes, it's going to be really somebody who's, who has a better [platform] profile who's going to be hired.

(female, highly urbanised city)

For Ines and several other participants, this produced pressure to bid for low-wage entry-level jobs despite the risk of underemployment or reduced income. Others, however, resisted this platform logic because their position in the wider labour market afforded them alternative opportunities and their private circumstances did not demand an immediate increase in earnings. For example, Tala, a 26-year-old single woman living with her parents and free from significant financial responsibilities, had secured two high-paying, long-term clients through friends. She was therefore unwilling to pursue the small, low-paid tasks typically required of new-to-Upwork freelancers, considering such work only if she were to lose her existing clients:

I'm actually asking for \$8 per hour. Yeah, so maybe I will consider lowering that for maybe \$5 per hour for some time. And then I will look for some mini Upwork jobs.

And then, once I have built my credibility, maybe I can go for the specific tasks that I already am knowledgeable.

(female, highly urbanised city)

These contrasting practices illustrate how freelancers' capacity to follow or resist financial platform logics is shaped by the combined influence of the platform environment, their position within the wider labour market, and the circumstances of their private lives.

5.2 | Managing Temporal Resources

In addition to financial pressures, participants described how Upwork's platform environment imposes considerable temporal demands on new freelancers in their pursuance of jobs. Fierce competition on the site (Beerepoot and Lambregts 2015) meant that securing work required close monitoring of postings and rapid submission of proposals. As Ethan explained:

Clients check for applications just minutes after their job posting. Bidding for jobs that are recently posted can guarantee that a client views the application.

(male, component city)

Similarly, Rodrigo underscored the advantage of applying early, when the number of existing applicants is still low:

I think there's a lot of chances to win them if you were one of those first 20 person to send a proposal.

(male, component city)

To meet these expectations, participants felt compelled to be online frequently, especially during nighttime when clients from the United States—one of Upwork's most active markets—tend to post jobs. As they described:

You need to be online almost every hour to see, and then we're gonna refresh if what was the most recent job that was posted.

(Myra, female, highly urbanised city)

If you've opened hours for the [United States] office hours, you're gonna start maybe at 1 h after. There's the peak of people who need to do something like um, 'We're looking for leads, 100 leads. Turnaround time 24 h.' [...] I think I was awake at 1 am to 3 am [to search and bid for jobs].

(Reese, female, highly urbanised city)

These expectations of continuous availability and swift responsiveness illustrate a central feature of platformic management (see also Shevchuk et al. 2021). As such, securing jobs depends not only on freelancers' financial resources but also on their temporal capacity—shaped by their wider labour-market commitments and gendered responsibilities within their private lives—to remain consistently active on the platform.

Participants demonstrated notable gendered differences in their ability to align with these temporal platform demands. Reflecting prevailing gender norms in the Philippines (see also World Bank 2021), they described women as primarily responsible for caregiving and household tasks, and men as primary breadwinners:

I need to [take care of my children] because, as a mom, they need my attention.

(Ivy, female, component city)

I'm the wife, so I should do the household chores.

(Pia, female, highly urbanised city)

So, I'm a woman. [...] So it really should be my husband that's going to [financially] support and like get us from our dad's side. So we really need to have someone that can take care of us.

(Daria, female, highly urbanised city)

I do actually have the two job as well. To provide needs for my family. That's most important thing for me.

(Benjamin, male, highly urbanised city)

For male participants living in highly urbanised areas, the combination of these gendered private-sphere responsibilities and their position in the wider labour market strongly shaped the time they could allocate to Upwork. Many held stable full-time jobs in the IT-BPO sector, where employers typically provide health insurance with broader coverage than what is available to most Filipinos and often extend this to selected family members—a benefit participants valued greatly. Given their role as primary breadwinners, this stability and access to employer-provided healthcare made full-time formal employment a priority. As Benjamin, who worked full-time in an IT-BPO company, explained:

That's one of the things that's stopping me to go freelancing. Because [then] we [referring to himself, his wife, and his son] don't have any insurance to cover for our sicknesses or every time that we go to hospital.

(male, highly urbanised city)

These commitments left male participants with little time to engage with the temporal requirements of the platform environment, such as monitoring postings, refreshing searches, and submitting timely bids. Nathan, who combined two local jobs—one at a health insurance company and one in the IT-BPO sector—to support his father through employer-provided healthcare, described how little time remained:

As long I finish my task, my laundry, my cleaning, I get an opportunity to look for a specific job. That's Saturday, Sundays. But on Mondays or Fridays.. that was on my current jobs right now.

(male, highly urbanised city)

Male participants also reported limited time to perform jobs on Upwork alongside their existing workload. Their long and inflexible schedules in the wider labour market restricted the kinds of tasks they could realistically take on through the platform. As a result, they confined themselves to part-time projects that could be fitted around their primary employment. Benjamin, for example, sought online work merely to supplement what he considered an inadequate salary from his local IT-BPO job, yet his daily routine—leaving home at 5 AM and returning around 4:30 PM—left him with only a narrow evening window for online tasks: 'I don't want to die early. So I'm looking for 6 PM until 11 PM in the Philippines.' With so little temporal flexibility, he applied for only a few jobs and struggled to secure work on the platform. Similarly, Tomas, who held a full-time IT-BPO role and already had one freelance client via Facebook, had never applied for a single job on Upwork. As he explained:

I think I need to be more active, reaching out to clients [on Upwork] myself [but] I'm concerned about it might um.. consume much of my available time, because currently that now I have my corporate job and on my free time I do this client, client number one. And then, my concern is if I get client number two, then where will I get my time to rest or to spend with my family?

Taken together, these experiences show how men's capacity to search for and carry out online jobs is jointly shaped by platform-specific temporal expectations, the demands of formal employment, and gendered concerns about income security and family obligations. In doing so, they reveal why male freelancers in urban settings often act against Upwork's temporal logics and, in practice, deprioritise the platform when pursuing online jobs.

In contrast, female participants typically assumed the bulk of social reproductive responsibilities within their households. As in earlier studies, they turned to online freelancing in part for the temporal flexibility it offered in balancing paid work with caregiving (James 2022, 2024; Dunn et al. 2021; Tintiangko and Soriano 2020). Yet, unlike women in the United States and the United Kingdom—who often report persistent tensions between caregiving and the temporal demands embedded in platform logics (James 2022, 2024; Dunn et al. 2021)—the women in this study described feeling less constrained. Their ability to accommodate the temporal expectations of the platform environment was supported by gendered arrangements within the private sphere, including access to extended family members, typically mothers or mothers-in-law, who stepped in when scheduling conflicts arose. As Divina, mother of a 7-month-old, explained:

it's okay if I will work as a customer representative that will be taking calls, because I can ask my mother-in-law to take care of my son.

(female, component city)

Other women negotiated these demands by managing paid online work while simultaneously caring for children or elderly

parents. Daria, who had a 3-year-old, described how such arrangements unfolded in practice:

I get to talk to my son that I'm working, I need to work. He's really listening to me. When he knows that I'm going to work, then he's gonna behave and I can do my job.
(female, highly urbanised city)

Moreover, female participants reported feeling less restricted by their caregiving responsibilities, as many Upwork jobs are from American or European clients, who require them to work at night when their children and parents are asleep. While this affected their sleep, they viewed such hours as 'normal' (Abby, female, highly urbanised city) and something they are 'used to' (Maribel, female, component city), having previously worked similar shifts in IT-BPO companies.

Overall, the comparison shows that freelancers' capacity to navigate Upwork's temporal logics is shaped by gendered configurations of work and care. Whereas men's breadwinner roles and full-time commitments curtailed both their search time and ability to take on online work, women leveraged familial support and experience with nocturnal work rhythms to accommodate platform demands, albeit within the constraints of their reproductive responsibilities. Together, these gendered trajectories illustrate the central premise of this article's analytical framework: that freelancers' labour agency on Upwork takes shape through the combined influence of the platform environment, their labour-market position, and the gendered organisation of their private lives.

6 | Discussion and Conclusion

Online freelance platforms are known to fragment work into smaller, short-term tasks, reflecting a broader transformation in the world of work (Graham et al. 2017). This article advances our understanding of how online freelancers navigate this shift by introducing a novel analytical framework that situates freelancers' labour agency within three interrelated dimensions: the platform environment, freelancers' broader labour market position, and their gendered roles in the domestic sphere. Focussing on freelancers' agency in choosing between online jobs, the findings show that they draw on two overarching sets of strategies—optimising their financial resources and managing their temporal resources—when deciding which jobs to pursue. Their ability and willingness to follow the financial and temporal logics embedded in Upwork's platform environment are shaped by constraints and opportunities in the wider labour market and their private lives. Namely, these contexts condition freelancers' access to time and money, shaping the very strategies they rely on when navigating the platform environment. These structurally conditioned strategies, while rational within their broader socio-economic context, often lead them to deprioritise Upwork, limiting their ability to accumulate platform reputation on which future access to work depends. Prior research has shown that such reputation and the on-platform experience that underpins it is essential for generating a stable flow of work and income from the platform over time (Pallais 2014; Demirel et al. 2021; Graham et al. 2017).

Building on these findings, the analytical framework demonstrates its value by offering new insights into why some workers succeed on online freelance platforms while others do not (Oprins 2025). The findings reveal gendered inner family dynamics that shape freelancers' capacity to adhere to platform logics. Many female participants pursued online freelancing to gain the temporal flexibility needed to balance paid work with social reproductive labour, which they perceived as their primary responsibility. Unlike women in the Global North, who often struggle to adhere to temporal platform logics due to time constraints imposed by caregiving duties (James 2022, 2024; Dunn et al. 2021), women in this study experienced greater time flexibility, needed to effectively select and land jobs and build a solid platform reputation. This was facilitated by support from extended family and the ability to manage caregiving alongside online freelance work. In contrast, male participants in urban settings who identified as primary breadwinners often adopted moonlighting strategies (Shevchuk et al. 2024) or hybrid entrepreneurial models (Bögenhold 2019a), combining full-time, local employment with online freelancing. Their limited availability and inability to invest flexible time in securing online freelance jobs placed them at a disadvantage in building their Upwork career.

The implications for gender inequality in the Philippines are complex and remain ambiguous. On one hand, online freelance labour reinforces existing inequalities by pushing women into precarious platform work due to prevailing gender norms around caregiving (Anwar 2022). Online freelance platforms may also perpetuate gendered constructions of care by confining women to the domestic sphere rather than challenging these norms (James 2024). On the other hand, prior research shows that online freelancing does not necessarily result in income precarity (Elbanna and Idowu 2022) and there are numerous examples of freelancers in low-wage countries earning incomes that are relatively high compared to traditional employment (Elbanna and Idowu 2022; Soriano et al. 2021; D'Cruz and Noronha 2016; Anwar and Graham 2021; Graham et al. 2017).

The framework also sheds light on how freelancers strategically source digital jobs. While platforms like Upwork are designed as self-contained digital ecosystems with lock-in effects—such as non-transferable reputation systems (Kinder et al. 2019; Jarrahi et al. 2020; Sutherland et al. 2020; Rahman 2021; Bucher et al. 2021)—freelancers often navigate a broader ecosystem of multiple digital (labour) platforms and personal networks (see also Kinder et al. (2019), Rahman (2021), Anwar and Graham (2020), and Malik et al. (2021)). Securing jobs elsewhere reduces their adherence to the financial and temporal logics of any single platform. These findings suggest that online freelance platforms should be understood as one component within a broader portfolio of income-generating strategies (see also Shevchuk et al. 2024).

To conclude, this article demonstrates how broadening the analytical scope enriches debates on the uneven gains of remote platform work. While the empirical focus is on Upwork freelancers in the Philippines, the findings offer valuable insights into online freelance labour in the Global South and illustrate how freelancers' lived experiences diverge from those in the Global North. The proposed analytical framework provides a useful tool for future research to deepen our understanding of

how online freelancers' labour agency unfolds—not only among online freelancers but also among gig workers on crowdwork and location-based platforms. Although contextual adaptation may be necessary—for instance, considering the relevance of the overseas labour market (see Figure 1)—the framework's emphasis on freelancers' socio-cultural and economic context could help to further unpack the heterogeneity of their digital work portfolios. Moreover, it could offer guidance for examining how freelancers combine traditional, analogue employment with online freelancing, and how this varies across groups (Bögenhold 2019; Shevchuk et al. 2024). A longitudinal approach would be particularly valuable in disentangling the complex and ambiguous implications for gender inequality. More broadly, this article calls for future research to contextualise freelancers' behaviour within their local realities. After all, despite online freelance platforms' aim to delocalise work (Horton 2010), the findings demonstrate that freelancers remain deeply embedded in their socio-cultural and economic environments.

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Conflicts of Interest

The author declares no conflict of interest.

Endnotes

- ¹ In the Philippines, a significant portion of the population (about 38% in 2017) is informally employed (Navarro et al. 2021). There is a lack of data on the proportion of women engaged in informal employment.

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